



Politics and Governance in the “Semi-Democracy Era” (1978–2000)

CHAPTER FIVE

POLITICS AND GOVERNMENT OF THAILAND

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I Constitutional Framework and the Onset of Semi-Democracy

The **1978 Constitution of the Kingdom of Thailand (B.E. 2521)** reintroduced a bicameral structure, providing for a **House of Representatives** elected by the people and a **Senate** appointed by the King upon the recommendation of the Prime Minister.

Civil servants were eligible for appointment to the Senate, reinforcing bureaucratic influence within the legislature. The Prime Minister and Cabinet ministers were not required to be members of Parliament, and under transitional provisions, career civil servants could occupy executive positions during the first term.

Notably, the inaugural Senate was granted powers equal to those of the House in votes of no confidence, underscoring the military's reluctance to entrust full authority to elected representatives. While the Constitution did not prohibit MPs from serving as Prime Minister or ministers, the design reflected continued elite skepticism toward the stability of parliamentary politics and a desire to insulate the executive from partisan lobbying.

This framework ushered in what scholars have termed an era of “semi-democracy.” Political power was accessed through electoral processes, with general elections held in 1979, 1983, 1986, and 1988. Prem Tinsulanonda (1980–1988).

Each time, the House of Representatives formally selected the Prime Minister, but the office was consistently occupied by senior military figures—General Kriangsak Chomanan (1979–1980) and General Prem Tinsulanonda (1980–1988).

Civilian parties gained seats and competed actively, but their weakness and fragmentation enabled military leaders to retain ultimate authority.

It was only after the general election of 24 July 1988 that this pattern shifted: General Prem declined reappointment, and the House selected General Chatichai Choonhavan, leader of the Chart Thai Party, as Prime Minister—the first elected politician to hold the office in over a decade. Yet Chatichai’s civilian government was short-lived, overthrown by a coup in 1991.

The first general election under the 1978 Constitution was held on 22 April 1979, returning 301 members to the House of Representatives under a multi-member constituency system (up to three representatives per district) with a ratio of one MP per 150,000 citizens.

Voter turnout reached 9.91 million (43.9 percent). Because political parties had not yet been legally institutionalized, candidates stood as independents or under informal group banners.

In total, 14 groups won representation alongside 44 independents. The Social Action Group won the largest share with 85 seats, followed by Chart Thai (42), the Democrat Group (34), Thai Population Group (32), and Seritham Group (22), among others.

After the election, General Kriangsak Chomanan, though not an MP, was chosen by Parliament to form a government on 12 May 1979 with support from multiple groups and independents.

His administration, however, proved fragile; on 29 February 1980, he announced his resignation in Parliament, citing mounting difficulties.

Without fresh elections, the House elected General Prem Tinsulanonda as Prime Minister on 3 March 1980, inaugurating a new phase of semi-democratic rule dominated by military–civilian compromise.

II

Premocracy and the Consolidation of Semi-Democracy

General Prem Tinsulanonda assumed the premiership on 3 March 1980 and went on to serve three consecutive terms, totaling nearly eight years.

Remarkably, Prem never formed his own political party nor contested elections; instead, his authority rested on parliamentary endorsement, royal confidence, and his ability to balance competing political forces.

During his tenure, he dissolved Parliament three times and survived two coup attempts, underscoring both the fragility of Thai democratic institutions and the resilience of military-backed leadership.



The **first dissolution** occurred on 19 March 1983, when the House of Representatives rejected a proposal to extend the transitional provisions of the 1978 Constitution.

The subsequent **general election of 18 April 1983** filled 324 seats under the same multi-member constituency system (up to three representatives per district), with the ratio of one MP per 150,000 citizens.

Parties were required to contest at least half of all constituencies, though independents were still permitted. Turnout reached 12.3 million (50.8 percent).



The **Chart Thai Party**, led by Major General Pramarn Adireksarn, won the largest number of seats (110), followed by the **Social Action Party** under M.R. Kukrit Pramoj (99) and the **Democrat Party** under Bhichai Rattakul (56). A coalition of the Social Action Party, Democrat Party, and smaller groups subsequently re-elected Prem as Prime Minister.

The second dissolution followed on 1 May 1986, after the government lost a vote on a Royal Decree concerning land transport.

The general election of 27 July 1986 returned 347 MPs under the same electoral framework, though by then transitional provisions had expired, requiring all candidates to affiliate with political parties. Voter turnout rose significantly to 16.1 million (61.4 percent). Out of 16 contesting parties, 15 won seats.

The Democrat Party emerged strongest with 100 seats, followed by Chart Thai (63), Social Action (53), and Sahaphum (34). These, alongside the Rassadorn Party (18), formed a coalition government, once again endorsing Prem as Prime Minister.

However, his third term lasted less than two years. On 29 April 1988, Prem dissolved Parliament following internal dissent in the Democrat Party, where the “10 January Group” defected on a Copyright Bill, prompting the Democrats’ withdrawal from his coalition.



The general election of 24 July 1988 marked a turning point. A total of 357 MPs were elected under the same multi-member system, with turnout climbing to 16.9 million (63.6 percent).

Fifteen parties secured seats, with Chart Thai leading (87), followed by Social Action (54), Democrats (48), Ruam Thai (35), and Thai Population (31). This time, Prem declined to continue in office.

Instead, the House of Representatives elected General Chatichai Choonhavan, leader of the Chart Thai Party, as Prime Minister. His appointment signaled a decisive break: Chatichai was the first party leader, elected MP, and parliamentary choice to serve as Prime Minister since the October 1976 crisis.



His rise suggested that by the late 1980s, the semi-democratic compromise—military leaders presiding over elected legislatures—was no longer sufficient to contain the pressures for fuller parliamentary democracy.

III

Semi-Democracy in the Post-Prem Era

The **1978 Constitution of the Kingdom of Thailand (B.E. 2521)** institutionalized a compromise in political power.

On the one hand, it restored direct elections to the House of Representatives, permitted the formation of political parties, and granted citizens a limited measure of political rights and freedoms.

On the other hand, it ensured the continued dominance of military and bureaucratic elites: the Prime Minister was not required to be an elected MP, key ministerial posts were reserved for senior bureaucrats, and the Senate was filled by appointees nominated by the Prime Minister.

While this arrangement gave elections a central role in legitimizing political leadership between 1978 and 1988, it also entrenched elite oversight of governance.

At the same time, the requirement that candidates contest elections only under party banners—and that parties field candidates in at least half of all constituencies—fueled the rise of **provincial political networks**.

Political parties became dependent on local patronage structures, including subdistrict and village leaders, business elites, and influential local figures, to mobilize votes and finance campaigns. This dynamic enhanced the political authority of so-called *jao pho* (local godfathers), who came to dominate networks of MPs.

After being elected Prime Minister on **4 August 1988**, General Chatichai Choonhavan formed a six-party coalition government composed of the Chart Thai Party, Social Action Party, Democrat Party, People's Party, United Democracy Party, and Mass Party.

His administration lasted just over two years before it was toppled by the NPKC coup on **23 February 1991**. This intervention led to the appointment of **Anand Panyarachun** as Prime Minister on **2 March 1991**.

Subsequent accession to political power followed mixed patterns: once through appointment by the coup-makers, once through a parliamentary vote on **22 March 1992** that made General **Suchinda Kraprayoon** Prime Minister despite not being an elected MP, and once through a parliamentary nomination on **10 June 1992**, when **Arthit Urairat**, Speaker of the House, proposed Anand Panyarachun for reappointment.

IV

Democratic Experimentation and the Return of Electoral Politics (1992–1997)

The second premiership of **Anand Panyarachun**, beginning on 10 June 1992, was established as a caretaker administration tasked with organizing fresh elections in the wake of the May 1992 crisis.

The general election was held on 13 September 1992, returning 360 members of the House of Representatives for four-year terms under the mixed direct election system (up to three MPs per constituency, with one MP per 150,000 citizens).

All candidates were required to run under party affiliation, and each party was obligated to nominate at least 120 candidates. Voter turnout reached 19.76 million, or 62.0 percent. The Democrat Party secured the largest share with 79 seats and formed a coalition with the New Aspiration Party, the Palang Dharma Party, the Social Action Party, and the Solidarity Party.

On 23 September 1992, Chuan Leekpai, leader of the Democrat Party, was appointed Prime Minister. His coalition government, however, was plagued by internal disputes and lasted just over two years before Chuan dissolved Parliament on 19 May 1995, following coalition infighting linked to a no-confidence debate over the controversial Sor Por Kor 4-01 land reform program. Elections were scheduled for 2 July 1995.

The 1995 general election increased the House to 391 seats under the same electoral framework. This was the first election to extend suffrage to citizens aged 18 and above. Turnout reached 23.46 million, or 62.4 percent. The Chart Thai Party won the largest number of seats (92).

On 13 July 1995, the House elected **Banharn Silpa-archa**, leader of Chart Thai, as Prime Minister. Banharn formed a seven-party coalition comprising the New Aspiration Party, Palang Dharma Party, Social Action Party, Thai Citizens Party, Nam Thai Party, and Mass Party.

Yet his administration proved unstable, lasting just over a year.

On 27 September 1996, Banharn dissolved Parliament, barely a week after a no-confidence debate led by the Democrat Party accused his government of inefficiency and failure to deliver on its stated policies.

The 1996 general election took place on 17 November 1996, electing 393 MPs under the same multi-member constituency system. Turnout reached 24.07 million, or 62.4 percent.

The New Aspiration Party emerged strongest with 125 seats, and on 25 November 1996, the House elected its leader, General Chavalit Yongchaiyudh, as Prime Minister. Chavalit formed a coalition with the National Development Party, Social Action Party, Thai Citizens Party, Seritham Party, and Mass Party.

However, his government quickly faltered in the face of the 1997 Asian Financial Crisis. On 9 November 1997, Chavalit resigned, and the House elected Chuan Leekpai, leader of the Democrat Party—which held the second largest number of seats—as Prime Minister.

Chuan's second administration governed almost to the completion of the parliamentary term before dissolving the House and calling new elections for **6 January 2001**.

The post-Prem period highlighted the paradox of Thailand's democratic development: while elections became the primary channel for legitimizing political power, the persistence of military influence, weak party institutionalization, and the dominance of provincial patronage networks produced fragile coalition governments and recurrent instability.

The frequent dissolutions of Parliament, short-lived administrations, and reliance on local political brokers underscored the limitations of the system established under **the 1978 and 1991 Constitutions**.

Ultimately, the crises of 1991 and 1997 demonstrated the unsustainability of this arrangement and paved the way for the reformist 1997 Constitution, which sought to strengthen political parties and reconfigure the relationship between electoral legitimacy and executive authority.

Recommended Further Readings

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